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UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

FRIDAY, 23 OCTOBER 2026

21 must-know stories, 24 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 945 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court holds voters can prosecute candidates for concealing information

A Bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu delivered this judgment clarifying who can initiate complaints against candidates. The Supreme Court held that ordinary voters are legally eligible to lodge complaints and prosecute electoral candidates who conceal information. The judgment by a Bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu said the law does not insist that only public servants or competent authorities were eligible to lodge complaints against electoral candidates

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu · **Prelims:** The judgment was delivered by Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu.; The court held that the law does not restrict complaints to public servants or competent authorities alone.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Empowers individual citizens to hold electoral candidates accountable for non-disclosure of facts.; Enhances transparency and integrity in the electoral process by widening the scope of complainants.*

Static — The Representation of the People Act, 1951 governs the conduct of elections in India, including provisions for disqualification and disclosure of candidate assets and criminal antecedents. Candidates contesting elections are legally mandated to file an affidavit disclosing criminal records, assets, liabilities, and educational qualifications. Concealing material information or filing false affidavits in nomination papers amounts to an electoral malpractice and can be grounds for election petitions.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

The Hindu: read the source

Governance & Policy

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Third Regional Review Conference on Forest Rights Act Implementation Held in Srinagar

The conference was held to conclude the regional review series following earlier meetings in Bengaluru and Kolkata. The Ministry of Tribal Affairs convened the Third Regional Review Conference on the Forest Rights Act in Srinagar to review implementation progress and challenges across several States and Union Territories. Senior officials from Maharashtra, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Goa, Rajasthan and Jammu & Kashmir reviewed implementation progress, discussed challenges and identified priority actions. Shri Mohd Mumtaz Ali, Director, Tribal Affairs Department, Gov

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir · **Who:** Ministry of Tribal Affairs, Shri Javed Ahmed Rana, Shri Anant Prakash Pandey, Shri Mohd Mumtaz Ali · **Prelims:** The Third Regional Review Conference on the FRA took place in Srinagar.; The first and second regional conferences were held in Bengaluru and Kolkata respectively.; As of 31 August 2026, approximately 54 lakh claims had been received nationally.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides a platform for States to share best practices and address bottlenecks in recognizing forest rights.; Emphasizes transparency, reasoned rejections and adherence to statutory appeals for forest-dependent communities.*

Static — The Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006, recognises the rights of forest-dwelling tribal communities and other traditional forest dwellers. The Act addresses historical injustices faced by forest-dwelling communities during the colonial and post-independence periods regarding forest tenurial security. It provides for individual forest rights for habitation and self-cultivation, as well as community forest rights for grazing, fishing and access to minor forest produce.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Social Justice & Welfare, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

PIB: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Government Approves More Houses Under PMAY-U 2.0, Taking Total Beyond 20 Lakh

Recent government approvals crossed the 20 lakh mark for housing units under the PMAY-U 2.0 scheme. The government has approved additional houses under Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Urban 2.0, taking total sanctioned houses past 20 lakh.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Central Government, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs · **Prelims:** Scheme: Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Urban 2.0 (PMAY-U 2.0); Milestone: Total approved houses crossed 20 lakh

> ***Why it matters —*** *Accelerates the goal of providing affordable housing to urban populations in India.; Boosts welfare delivery and infrastructure development under urban administrative frameworks.*

Static — Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Urban (PMAY-U) is a flagship mission implemented by the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs. The original PMAY-U was launched in 2015 with the objective of providing housing for all in urban areas by 2022. PMAY-U 2.0 builds upon the initial phase to further cater to the housing needs of urban poor and middle-class families.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Social Justice & Welfare

Elets eGov: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Parliamentary panel seeks gender-inclusive urban criteria, flags no town councils in 3000 census towns

A parliamentary standing committee has called for a review of India's urban area criteria, noting that the existing test relies exclusively on male non-agricultural employment. The panel highlighted that the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India deemed MoHUA's proposed regional relaxations non-objective but never communicated this back. The core issue is that India's conventional definition of urban areas fails to capture women's economic participation and creates a gap with international definitions. Under existing criteria, a Census Town requires at least 5,000 population, 400 density per sq km, and 75 percent of the male main working population in non-agricultural activities. The committee recommended commissioning a focused study to develop a gender-inclusive methodology and conducting a gender audit of Census definitions and procedures. Over 3,000 Census Towns identified in 2011 continue to remain under rural local bodies without urban local governance despite meeting urban criteria. The panel recommended engaging with states and union territories after Census 2027 data release to examine converting eligible Census Towns into statutory urban local bodies. The existing census town criteria have been retained for Census 2027 to ensure comparability with the 2011 exercise.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Standing Committee on Housing and Urban Affairs, Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India (ORGI), Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) · **Prelims:** India was 36 percent urban under conventional definitions, while international definitions suggested it may have exceeded 50 percent.; A Census Town requires a minimum population of 5,000 and a density of at least 400 people per square kilometre.; Of the 3,892 Census Towns identified in 2011, 175 have been notified as statutory towns and 367 have merged with existing statutory towns.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the undercounting of women's informal and home-based work in official economic and urban metrics.; Exposes governance deficits where densely populated census towns lack proper urban infrastructure and municipal funding.*

Static — Urbanisation in India is measured using categories like statutory towns (having municipal bodies) and census towns (rural areas satisfying urban demographic thresholds). The Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India (ORGI) functions under the Ministry of Home Affairs and conducts the decennial Census. The Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA) is responsible for formulating policies, urban development programs, and framing urban governance frameworks in India.

Syllabus: GS2: Governance & Policy, Social Justice & Welfare, Geography · Prelims angle: Report/Index

Hindustan Times: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India Notifies New Vehicle Crash-Safety Regulations: Stricter Crash Tests From October 2027

The government officially issued the notification for the new vehicle crash-safety regulations. India notified new vehicle crash-safety regulations that mandate stricter crash tests starting from October 2027.

When: October 2027 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Road Transport and Highways · **Prelims:** New vehicle crash-safety regulations notified.; Stricter crash tests scheduled to begin from October 2027.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Crucial for improving passenger safety and reducing road fatalities in India.; Pushes domestic automakers to adopt advanced global safety designs.*

Static — Vehicle safety standards in India are regulated by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways under the Central Motor Vehicles Rules. The Bharat New Car Assessment Programme (Bharat NCAP) evaluates vehicle safety performance through crash testing. India has progressively mandated features like airbags, ABS, and rear parking sensors to improve occupant protection.

Syllabus: GS3: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

Auto Punditz: read the source

International Relations

GS2 MAKE NOTES

India, China agree to discuss ways to improve understanding of LAC for better border management: MEA

India and China have agreed to discuss ways to improve the understanding of the Line of Actual Control in appropriate areas for better border management. The Ministry of External Affairs stated that the border situation gets disturbed when Chinese forces diverge from established patrolling patterns. Both nations continue to use existing diplomatic and military mechanisms to resolve outstanding issues and prevent misunderstandings along the border. MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal emphasised that peace and tranquillity in border areas are essential for overall bilateral relations. Addressing other foreign policy matters, India confirmed it continues to facilitate the transport of life-saving medicines to Iran despite regional flight challenges. The MEA confirmed that fourteen Indian nationals involved in a yacht incident off the Yemen coast are safe in Hodeidah. India reiterated that its defence exports strictly adhere to national obligations, laws, and guidelines.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** New Delhi, India; China; Yemen; Saudi Arabia; Iran · **Who:** Randhir Jaiswal, MEA Spokesperson; DG ITBP · **Prelims:** Fourteen Indian nationals involved in a yacht incident off the Yemen coast are safe in Hodeidah.; Around 3,000 stranded Umrah pilgrims have travelled back home from Saudi Arabia.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights ongoing diplomatic efforts to manage tensions and prevent miscalculations along the India-China border.; Demonstrates India's consular commitment to ensuring the safety and repatriation of its citizens stranded abroad.*

Static — The Line of Actual Control is the demarcation line that separates Indian-controlled territory from Chinese-controlled territory in the Sino-Indian border dispute. India and China share a poorly demarcated border of over 3,400 kilometres spanning the Western, Middle, and Eastern sectors. Bilateral border management relies on various diplomatic and military mechanisms, including Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

newsonair.gov.in: read the source · also reported by The Hindu, Indian Express

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Organisation founded 80 years ago struggling to deliver peace today: India on need for UNSC reforms

India highlighted the UN Security Council's struggles to deliver peace and reconciliation in major global conflicts during a UN General Assembly address. India's Permanent Representative to the UN, Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni, stated that authority derived from WWII victory cannot compensate for today's unrepresentative UNSC deficit. The core debate centers on the legitimacy of a UN structure anchored in 1945 realities while current geopolitical challenges and global populations have drastically shifted. India pointed out that around 2.5 million Indians took part in world wars with 90,000 casualties, while four million died in the Bengal famine under colonial policies. The Asia-Pacific Group accounts for over 60 percent of the world's population but is limited to one permanent member and few elected seats. Europe currently holds two permanent members and three elected members, reflecting severe regional under-representation like Africa and Latin America. India criticized the Intergovernmental Negotiations (IGN) process for proceeding without a text, timeframe, or defined end goal for over a decade and a half. India opposes a two-tier permanent membership regarding the veto power, asserting that all new and old permanent members must hold the veto fairly.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** United Nations, New York · **Who:** Ambassador Harish Parvathaneni · **Prelims:** The UNSC consists of 15 member states, including five permanent veto-wielding members and 10 elected members.; Around 2.5 million Indians participated in the world wars, with about 90,000 dying in military service.; India is vying for a non-permanent UNSC seat for the 2028-29 term.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights India's push for a permanent seat and structural reform of the United Nations to reflect modern geopolitical realities.; Brings attention to the under-representation of the Global South, particularly Asia-Pacific, Africa, and Latin America.*

Static — The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, charged with ensuring international peace and security. Established in 1945 under the United Nations Charter, the UNSC comprises 15 member states: five permanent members with veto power and ten non-permanent members elected for two-year terms. The five permanent members of the UNSC are China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States, often referred to as the P5.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

The Hindu: read the source · free copy on deccanherald.com · also reported by Business Upturn, Hindustan Times, Mid-Day

GS2 MAKE NOTES

The Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness (IPMDA) : India’s Maritime Security Diplomacy Under the Quad Framework

The strategic importance of maritime security diplomacy and the operationalization of the IPMDA framework in the Indo-Pacific region put it in the news. The Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness (IPMDA) is a Quad initiative designed to track and monitor maritime activities across the Indo-Pacific.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** Indo-Pacific Region · **Who:** Quad Nations (India, US, Japan, Australia) · **Prelims:** IPMDA stands for Indo-Pacific Partnership for Maritime Domain Awareness.; The initiative operates under the Quad framework consisting of India, USA, Japan, and Australia.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Enhances regional maritime situational awareness for partner nations.; Strengthens India's strategic partnership within the Quad framework.*

Static — The Quad is an informal strategic dialogue between India, the United States, Japan, and Australia, aimed at ensuring a free and open Indo-Pacific. Maritime Domain Awareness (MDA) refers to the effective understanding of anything associated with the maritime domain that could impact security, safety, economy, or environment. Dark shipping involves vessels turning off their Automatic Identification System (AIS) transponders to evade tracking and engage in illegal activities.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Governance & Policy

IMPRI Impact and Policy Research Institute: read the source · also reported by PIB

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Medog Dam and Paizhen Fault, Location, Features and Significance

China is constructing the mega Medog Hydropower Project on the Yarlung Tsangpo River in Tibet with a planned capacity of roughly 60,000 MW. Recent geological research highlights potential risks associated with the Paizhen Fault, an active fault located right in the project area. The core debate centers on whether complex seismic activity, fractured rocks, and slope instability threaten the safety and structural integrity of the dam. Construction on the project commenced in July 2025, with completion targeted into the 2030s, specifically cited around 2033 in reports. The project is situated in Medog County, Tibet, approximately 50 km from the Indian border near the river's Great Bend. The Paizhen Fault lies in a tectonically active zone where the Indian Plate converges with the Eurasian Plate, showing activity since the Pleistocene Epoch. Geological concerns include foundation stability, earthquake hazards, landslides, slope collapse, river blockage, and reservoir-induced seismicity. The project raises downstream concerns for India because the Yarlung Tsangpo enters Arunachal Pradesh as the Siang River and forms the Brahmaputra. Implications for India include downstream water security, flood management challenges, ecological impacts, and limited transparency in hydrological data sharing.

When: July 2025 · **Where:** Medog County, Tibet Autonomous Region, China · **Who:** Chinese researchers and developers · **Prelims:** Planned capacity of the Medog Hydropower Project is approximately 60,000 MW or 60 GW.; Construction of the Medog project commenced in July 2025.; The project area is located approximately 50 km from the Indian border in Medog County, Tibet.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It directly impacts India's downstream water security and flood forecasting capabilities in Arunachal Pradesh and Assam.; It underscores the complex geopolitical dynamics and lack of robust transboundary water-data sharing mechanisms between India and China.*

Static — The Brahmaputra river system originates as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet, flows into India through Arunachal Pradesh as the Siang, and traverses Assam before entering Bangladesh. Transboundary water governance between India and China relies on institutional expert-level mechanisms and Memorandums of Understanding for hydrological data sharing during flood seasons. The eastern Himalayan region is a highly sensitive seismic zone characterized by active faults, steep gradients, and high vulnerability to landslides and earthquakes.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations, Infrastructure & Energy

Vajiram & Ravi: read the source

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Eleventh Amendment Directions, 2026

The RBI issued these new directions on October 23, 2026, to align domestic rules with the Basel Committee's leverage ratio 2017 standard. RBI/2026-27/297 DOR.CAP.REC.251/21-02-002/2026-27 October 23, 2026 Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Eleventh Amendment Directions, 2026 Please refer to 'Chapter VII: Leverage Ratio framework' of the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Directions, 2025 (hereinafter referred to as 'the Directions'). To ensure alignment with the latest leverage ratio framework ('leverage ratio 2017 standard') issued by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision, there is a felt need to amend these Directions. Accordingly, in exercise of the powers conferred by Section 35A of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949 and all…

When: October 23, 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** The notification is titled Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Eleventh Amendment Directions, 2026.; The notification date is October 23, 2026.; The powers were exercised under Section 35A of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Ensures Indian commercial banks maintain robust leverage ratios aligned with international Basel standards.; Strengthens the financial resilience of the banking sector against unexpected economic shocks.*

Static — The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is India's central banking institution, established on April 1, 1935, under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. Section 35A of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949 empowers the RBI to issue directions to banking companies in the public interest or to prevent banking policy from being detrimentally affected. The Basel Committee on Banking Supervision (BCBS) is the primary global standard-setter for the prudential regulation of banks and provides a forum for regular cooperation on banking supervisory matters.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Polity & Constitution, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

RBI: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Changes in PLFS schedule and estimation procedure from January 2027

The Statistics Ministry invited comments from policymakers, academic and research institutions, and the general public on proposed changes to the Periodic Labour Force Survey schedule and estimation procedure. The National Statistics Office has conducted the Periodic Labour Force Survey since 2017 to meet the growing demand for timely and disaggregated labour market statistics. A new Second Stage Stratum based on digital platform work is being introduced to improve coverage of digital platform workers, as existing arrangements captured inadequate numbers. Fresh samples for the 2027-2028 period will be drawn from an updated sampling frame reflecting changes in urbanisation, administrative boundaries, and rural Census 2011 frames. There will be four Second Stage Stratums in rural areas and five in urban areas, with 14 households canvassed in each selected First Stage Unit. For the first three months of 2027, the sample will use pooled monthly estimates from both Panel 5 and the updated Panel 6 frames without Relative Standard Error estimates. New questions are added to Schedule 10.4 to measure unpaid activities like own-use production of goods, caregiving, volunteer work, and unpaid trainee work for persons aged 15 and above.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** National Statistics Office, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation · **Prelims:** The Periodic Labour Force Survey has been conducted by the National Statistics Office since 2017.; A new Second Stage Stratum based on digital platform work introduces four strata in rural areas and five in urban areas.; Information on digital platform workers has been collected on an experimental basis since January 2026.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Improves data collection on the rapidly growing gig and digital platform economy.; Enhances measurement of unpaid household, caregiving, and volunteer activities for better socio-economic policymaking.*

Static — The Periodic Labour Force Survey was launched in 2017 by the National Statistical Office under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation to measure employment and unemployment indicators. The survey design provides estimates of key employment indicators like the Worker Population Ratio, Labour Force Participation Rate, and Unemployment Rate in both rural and urban areas. The National Statistical Office is responsible for conducting large-scale sample surveys across India in various fields, functioning under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Social Justice & Welfare · Prelims angle: Report/Index

PIB: read the source · free copy on ptinews.com · also reported by Economic Times, The Hindu, All India Radio (NewsOnAir), BusinessLine, Indian Express

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Strong macro fundamentals, policy interventions to anchor eco against global headwinds: RBI bulletin

The RBI Bulletin's article on 'State of the Economy' stated that strong macroeconomic fundamentals and targeted policy interventions continue to anchor the Indian economy against global headwinds. Global economic prospects face downside risks from rising inflationary pressures induced by the West Asia crisis, supply chain disruptions, and trade tensions. Elevated sovereign bond yields in advanced economies, public debt, and fiscal sustainability concerns are creating global financial stability risks. Despite being a net energy importer, India's GDP growth has been supported by sustained domestic demand, industry and services high-frequency indicators. Headline consumer price index inflation edged up and showed generalisation across commodities, calling for a commensurate change in monetary policy stance. The Reserve Bank deployed regulatory measures to curb speculative activity in the foreign exchange market, while FCNR(B) swap inflows augmented reserves. FDI flows remained robust in August 2026, with communication, miscellaneous services and manufacturing receiving over two-thirds of the inflows. The US, Singapore, and Mauritius were the major source countries accounting for about 72 per cent of FDI inflows.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** Mumbai · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** The major source countries accounting for about 72 per cent of FDI inflows were the US, Singapore, and Mauritius.; Communication, miscellaneous services, and manufacturing received more than two-thirds of the FDI inflows in August 2026.; The rupee exhibited a depreciating bias since late September due to a stronger US dollar and surging crude oil prices before appreciating in mid-October.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides official central bank insights into India's economic resilience against global shocks.; Highlights crucial data regarding FDI inflows, currency movements, and inflation trends relevant for economic planning and UPSC GS-3 preparation.*

Static — The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is India's central banking institution, established on April 1, 1935, under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. The primary mandate of the RBI includes regulating the issue of bank notes, maintaining monetary stability in India, and operating the currency and credit system. Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in India is regulated under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) and policies formulated by the central government.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy, International Relations · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Economic Times: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by ANI News, BusinessLine

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Govt sets rules for Rs. 84,084 cr offshore oil hunt, to share drilling risks

The government introduced operational guidelines for the Rs 84,084-crore Samudra Manthan scheme to share high-risk deepwater oil and gas exploration costs with energy companies. The scheme addresses high drilling costs and uncertain geological prospects that have constrained investment in India's deepwater and ultra-deepwater basins, aiming to cut import reliance. The programme will run through FY2030-31, featuring FY2026-27 as a preparatory year followed by Phase I spending from FY2027-28 onwards. Petroleum Secretary Neeraj Mittal stated the scheme could add more than 600 million tonnes of oil equivalent to India's reserves. The central component provides financial support for 56 exploratory wells and 4 stratigraphic wells in waters deeper than 400 metres and 1,500 metres. Exploratory well funding covers up to 50 percent of actual costs capped at Rs 675 crore per well, while stratigraphic wells cover up to 100 percent capped at Rs 1,350 crore per well. Only state-owned companies or consortia led by them can apply for stratigraphic well funding, which is restricted to blocks awarded under the Revenue Sharing Contract regime.

When: FY2026-27 to FY2030-31 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Neeraj Mittal, DGH · **Prelims:** Total outlay of the Samudra Manthan scheme is Rs 84,084 crore.; Deepwater and ultra-deepwater areas are defined as waters deeper than 400 metres and 1,500 metres respectively.; DGH acts as the implementing and nodal agency for the scheme.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Aims to add over 600 million tonnes of oil equivalent to India's domestic hydrocarbon reserves.; Mitigates high financial risks and upfront exploration burdens for energy companies in difficult deepwater terrains.*

Static — Upstream oil and gas exploration in India is governed by policies such as the Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP) and Revenue Sharing Contracts. The Directorate General of Hydrocarbons (DGH), under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, acts as the nodal agency for promoting and managing petroleum exploration and production data in India. Deepwater and ultra-deepwater basins involve complex technology and high capital expenditure, making risk-sharing mechanisms critical for attracting private and public investments.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy, Infrastructure & Energy · Prelims angle: Scheme, Data/Stats

Business Standard: read the source · free copy on msn.com

GS3 MAKE NOTES

RBI's Rs. 2.5 trillion liquidity infusion sends mixed signals: SBI Research

The Reserve Bank of India raised the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50% while injecting Rs. 2.5 lakh crore into the banking system. SBI Research flagged a potential contradiction between the central bank's calibrated tightening stance and its liquidity injection operations. The report questioned why the RBI conducted three liquidity-injection repo operations from October 19 onwards when policy aimed to tighten conditions. All six Monetary Policy Committee members voted for the rate increase, but only four backed the shift to calibrated tightening while two preferred neutrality. Liquidity operations influence funds available to banks and short-term rates, making simultaneous injections and withdrawals appear inconsistent. SBI Research noted the RBI pursued tightening via open market operations and variable rate reverse repo operations alongside the liquidity injection. The report acknowledged financial stability concerns could have influenced the RBI but argued conflicting signals complicate monetary policy transmission. SBI Research does not expect government bond yields to decline significantly, noting elevated crude oil prices and US Treasury yields keep borrowing costs high.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India, SBI Research, Monetary Policy Committee · **Prelims:** The repo rate was raised by 25 basis points to 5.50%.; The RBI conducted three liquidity-injection repo operations starting October 19.; Retail inflation rose to 5.54% in September, nearing the 6% tolerance ceiling.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the operational challenges and communication dilemmas central banks face in balancing inflation control with financial stability.; Demonstrates how mixed monetary policy signals can affect market certainty, bond yields, and borrowing costs.*

Static — The Monetary Policy Committee is a statutory body constituted under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The repo rate is the interest rate at which the central bank lends money to commercial banks in the event of any shortfall of funds. The Liquidity Adjustment Facility is a monetary policy tool used by the RBI to absorb or inject liquidity into the banking system through repo and reverse repo agreements.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy

Business Standard: read the source · free copy on businesstoday.in · also reported by Economic Times, Business Today

GS3 MAKE NOTES

RBI flags rising inflation risks from West Asia conflict, El Nino despite resilient Indian economy

The Reserve Bank of India noted that the domestic economy remains resilient but faces growing inflation risks from West Asia tensions and El Nino. This warning was published in the State of the Economy article in the RBI October Bulletin. The core issue is balancing strong domestic growth momentum against external supply-chain shocks, rising energy costs, and volatile global financial markets. Headline CPI inflation rose to 5.54% in September from 4.82% in August, driven by broad-based increases in food, fuel, and core components. Domestic economic resilience is supported by robust high-frequency indicators across industry, healthy services, strong consumer demand, and double-digit merchandise export growth. India's external position showed resilience via narrowed trade deficits, strong foreign direct investment, remittance inflows, and overseas borrowings. The RBI had earlier hiked interest rates by 25 basis points with a hawkish stance, indicating that policy rate cuts are unlikely soon.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** Mumbai, India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and International Monetary Fund (IMF) · **Prelims:** Headline CPI inflation rose to 5.54% in September, up from 4.82% in August.; The IMF raised India's GDP growth forecast for 2026-27 to 7%, a 60 basis points upgrade.; The IMF projected global economic growth at 3.1% in 2026 and 3.4% in 2027.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Signals a prolonged pause on interest rate reductions to anchor medium-term inflation expectations.; Highlights vulnerability of domestic food and fuel prices to imported global commodity and geopolitical shocks.*

Static — The Reserve Bank of India was established on April 1, 1935, under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, based on the Hilton Young Commission recommendations. Under Section 45ZB of the amended RBI Act, the Monetary Policy Committee sets the policy repo rate to achieve the inflation target. India adopted a flexible inflation targeting framework in 2016, mandating a 4% Consumer Price Index target with a tolerance band of plus or minus 2%.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Geography, International Relations · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Economic Times: read the source · free copy on msn.com · also reported by La Via Campesina

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India's net FDI inflows rise to $13.8 billion in April-August FY27: RBI

The Reserve Bank of India released updated balance of payments and foreign investment data for the April-August period. India's net foreign direct investment inflows rose to $13.8 billion in the April-August period of FY27, up from $9.6 billion a year ago. Net FDI inflows increased from $9.6 billion a year ago, supported by higher gross inward investment and a slowdown in outward FDI, according to Reserve Bank of India data

When: April-August FY27 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** Net FDI inflows reached $13.8 billion in April-August FY27.; Net FDI inflows in the corresponding period a year ago stood at $9.6 billion.; Data was released by the Reserve Bank of India.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reflects investor confidence in the Indian economy and domestic market potential.; Supports the capital account of the balance of payments and foreign exchange reserves.*

Static — Foreign Direct Investment refers to an investment made by a firm or individual in one country into business interests located in another country. The Reserve Bank of India regulates foreign exchange flows and compiles balance of payments data including foreign direct investment. FDI can enter through the automatic route where no prior government approval is required or the government approval route.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy

Business Standard: read the source

Agriculture & Allied

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Centre to create 1 lakh soil health entrepreneurs, draft policy ready, says ICAR DG Jat

ICAR Director General Jat announced that the draft policy is ready following a year of consultations. The Centre has prepared a draft Bharat Soil Health Policy to create one lakh soil health entrepreneurs. “We’ve been discussing with a range of stakeholders over past one year to launch the Bharat Soil Health Policy. We did a lot of regional consultations as well,” Jat said

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India · **Who:** ICAR DG Jat · **Prelims:** Target is to create 1 lakh soil health entrepreneurs.; The proposed policy is named Bharat Soil Health Policy.; ICAR Director General is Jat.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Enhances rural livelihoods by creating local business opportunities in agriculture.; Improves soil health monitoring and fertilizer management at the farm level.*

Static — The Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR) is an autonomous body responsible for coordinating agricultural education and research in India. ICAR was established on July 16, 1929, under the Societies Registration Act, 1860, and operates under the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare. Soil health management in India is heavily supported by the Soil Health Card Scheme launched to assist farmers with nutrient recommendations.

Syllabus: GS3: Agriculture & Allied, Governance & Policy

BusinessLine: read the source

Environment & Ecology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India's first snow leopard survey records 718 across Himalayas, 477 in Ladakh: Kirti Vardhan Singh

India has recorded 718 snow leopards across the Indian Himalayan region, according to the first Snow Leopard Population Assessment in India survey. Union Minister Kirti Vardhan Singh announced these findings on the occasion of International Snow Leopard Day. Ladakh accounts for the highest share with 477 snow leopards out of the total 718 recorded across the country. The government emphasized its commitment to securing the species through habitat protection and community engagement. In a related development, India extended privileges and immunities to the International Big Cat Alliance under the United Nations Act of 1947. Union Environment Minister Bhupendra Yadav stated this step empowers the alliance to function as an effective global conservation platform.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** India, Ladakh, Himalayas · **Who:** Kirti Vardhan Singh, Bhupendra Yadav · **Prelims:** Total snow leopards recorded in India is 718.; Ladakh accounts for 477 snow leopards.; Privileges and immunities were extended under the United Nations (Privileges & Immunities) Act, 1947.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides baseline empirical data for formulating targeted conservation policies for high-altitude ecosystems.; Strengthens India's diplomatic and institutional leadership in global wildlife and big cat conservation.*

Static — The snow leopard is listed as Vulnerable on the IUCN Red List and is protected under Schedule I of India's Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. They inhabit high-altitude alpine zones of the Himalayas and Central Asia, earning them the moniker Ghost of the Mountains. The International Big Cat Alliance is a global initiative launched by India to ensure the conservation of seven major big cat species.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Geography, Internal Security · Prelims angle: Report/Index, Species

msn.com: read the source

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court expands wetland demarcation mandate, cites drinking water protection

The Supreme Court expanded the scope of identification and demarcation of wetlands to cover all water bodies across the country. A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi passed the order in petitions seeking the preservation of wetlands. The court observed that unprotected water bodies serving as drinking water sources directly threaten the Right to Life under Article 21. Petitioners like Anand Arya informed the bench that states and union territories have failed to complete the required wetland demarcation. Several states claimed that wetlands from the 2021 Atlas were untraceable or fell outside the definition under the 2017 Rules. The Supreme Court cited Tamil Nadu as a model state for completing ground-truthing in four stages out of its 28,898 wetlands. The court directed all states and wetland authorities to file compliance affidavits within four weeks detailing their demarcation progress.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi, Anand Arya · **Prelims:** The 2021 Space Applications Centre (SAC) Wetlands Atlas was prepared under ISRO.; Tamil Nadu has 28,898 wetlands and was cited by the court as a model state for demarcation.; The Supreme Court bench handling the matter comprised Justices Aravind Kumar and Vipul M Pancholi.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reinforces the constitutional link between environmental protection and the Right to Life under Article 21.; Expands judicial oversight from merely listed wetlands to all water bodies, plugging regulatory gaps in local water conservation.*

Static — Wetlands in India are regulated under the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2017, framed under the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986. The Rules establish State Wetland Authorities to manage wetlands, prohibit certain activities like conversion for non-wetland uses, and maintain digital inventories. Article 21 of the Constitution guarantees the Right to Life, which the judiciary has expansively interpreted to include the right to clean drinking water and a pollution-free environment.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Environment & Ecology, Polity & Constitution, Health · Prelims angle: Judgment, Place in news

Hindustan Times: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Nepal to receive first-ever loss and damage fund payout after devastating floods

This allocation marks the first time the global climate fund has earmarked money for a specific country to address climate-induced losses. Nepal is set to receive $21.6 million from the United Nations Loss and Damage Fund following the Bhotekoshi floods. Climate experts have welcomed the decision as a landmark step, but the funding is only a fraction of the nearly $5 billion Nepal estimates it needs for recovery and reconstruction.

When: August 2026 · **Where:** Nepal · **Who:** United Nations Loss and Damage Fund · **Prelims:** Nepal will receive $21.6 million from the UN Loss and Damage Fund.; The funding follows the Bhotekoshi floods that struck in August.; Nepal estimates it needs nearly $5 billion for recovery and reconstruction.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Marks a monumental shift in operationalizing global climate justice and financial aid for vulnerable developing nations.; Highlights the massive gap between actual climate funding provided and the actual reconstruction needs of developing countries like Nepal.*

Static — The Loss and Damage Fund was established to provide financial assistance to vulnerable developing countries that are particularly hit by the adverse effects of climate change. The fund was formally operationalized during the UN Climate Change Conference COP28 held in Dubai in 2023. It aims to address the unavoidable consequences of climate change that go beyond what countries can adapt to.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, International Relations, Disaster Management
The Hindu: read the source

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India became third-largest exporter of arms to Europe: Defence Secretary RK Singh

Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh announced that India has become the third-largest arms exporter to Europe. This growth is driven by surging demand under the Rearm Europe initiative and a broadening domestic manufacturing base. The core issue centres on expanding India's defence industrial base beyond traditional public sector units to include private players, MSMEs, and startups. India's defence exports have reached an all-time high of Rs. 38,424 crores (approx 3.6 billion euros), supplying ammunition and artillery to over 80 countries. Domestic defence sales have reached nearly 17 billion euros, supported by around 840 companies with industrial licences and 17,000 SMEs and startups. India prioritises Indian-Designed, Developed and Manufactured (IDDM) equipment to ensure technological sovereignty, aiming to spend 75% of annual capital expenditure domestically. India plans to participate in European arms procurement programmes by setting up joint ventures in Europe, while foreign entities entering India must meet local manufacturing mandates. While India's domestic localisation requirement is a minimum of 50%, European localisation norms are lighter at around 25%.

When: 2026-10-23 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Rajesh Kumar Singh (Defence Secretary) · **Prelims:** India's defence exports reached an all-time high of Rs. 38,424 crores (about 3.6 billion euros).; India currently exports defence products to more than 80 countries globally.; India mandates a minimum of 50% localisation for domestic defence procurement.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Marks a major milestone in India's journey towards defence export-led economic growth and strategic autonomy.; Demonstrates the success of the Atmanirbhar Bharat initiative in diversifying the defence industrial base.*

Static — India's defence export promotion is guided by policy shifts aimed at reducing import dependence and promoting self-reliance (Atmanirbhar Bharat) in the defence sector. The Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP) prioritises the IDDM (Indian-Designed, Developed and Manufactured) category as the most preferred option for defence capital acquisition. The Department of Defence Production under the Ministry of Defence oversees ordnance factories, public sector undertakings (DPSUs), and private sector participation through industrial licensing.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence · Prelims angle: Report/Index

Economic Times: read the source · *free copy on msn.com*

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

C-DAC and Bank of India Join Hands to Advance Indigenous Quantum Technologies for Banking Applications

The Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) and Bank of India (BOI) signed an MoU on October 22, 2026, to advance indigenous quantum and emerging technologies for banking. The partnership aims to make India's banking system more secure, resilient, and future-ready by tackling emerging cybersecurity challenges and exploring quantum innovations.

PIB: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY SCHEME QUICK READ

DDWS Organises National-level Training of Trainers under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 to Strengthen Community-led Rural Drinking Water Management

The National-level Training of Trainers programme for State-Level Trainers under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 was held at India Habitat Centre, New Delhi. The Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation organized a National-level Training of Trainers programme under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 to strengthen community-led rural drinking water management.

PIB: source

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE SCHEME QUICK READ

PM-DAKSH Scheme

The Department of Social Justice and Empowerment released training and placement figures for the PM-DAKSH scheme covering 2020-21 to 2023-24. A total of 1,87,305 candidates were trained and 96,162 secured job placements during this four-year implementation period. The scheme addresses low skill levels and limited employment opportunities among historically marginalized social groups.

Vajiram & Ravi: source

ECONOMY ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

RBI issues guidelines on the implementation of Leverage Ratio 2017 Standard

The Reserve Bank of India announced that the latest leverage ratio framework for banks issued by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision will take effect on April 1, 2027. The minimum leverage ratio is set at 4 per cent for domestic systemically important banks and 3.5 per cent for other commercial banks.

RBI: source

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

ICAR-CIRCOT Signs MoU for Technology Transfer of Protective Gloves for Cotton Picking Workers

ICAR-CIRCOT signed an MoU with a private firm for the technology transfer and commercialization of specially designed protective gloves for cotton picking workers. The ICAR–Central Institute for Research on Cotton Technology (ICAR-CIRCOT), Mumbai, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with M/s.

PIB: source

DEFENCE | EXERCISE | QUICK READ

CONCLUSION OF INDIA-RUSSIA BILATERAL NAVAL EXERCISE (INDRA 2026)

Indian Naval Ship Sahyadri departed from Vladivostok on October 20, 2026, marking the successful conclusion of the bilateral naval exercise Indra 2026. The exercise was conducted between the Indian Navy and the Russian Federation Navy (RuFN) to strengthen bilateral defense cooperation. The core issue focuses on enhancing maritime security, operational coordination, and interoperability between the two partner navies.

PIB: source

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE | SCHEME | QUICK READ

Atal Vayo Abhyuday Yojana Strengthens Integrated Care and Support for Senior Citizens

An official update from the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment detailed the current reach and implementation status of the scheme's components. Under the Integrated Programme for Senior Citizens (IPSrC) of Atal Vayo Abhyuday Yojana (AVYAY) implemented by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, the financial assistance is provided through a grant-in-aid mechanism to eligible organizations, including Non-Governmental Organizations, State Governments, Panchayati Raj Institutions and local bodies.

PIB: source

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT) Establishes Sixth Centre of Excellence (CoE) At IIT (BHU), Varanasi to Advance Next-Generation Telecom Technologies

C-DOT signed an MoU with IIT (BHU), Varanasi, to establish its sixth Centre of Excellence (CoE) to advance next-generation telecom technologies. The partnership bridges academic research with real-world technology requirements to build a skilled professional pipeline for the telecom sector. Researchers, faculty, and students from both entities will undertake joint research and promote knowledge exchange for native technologies.

PIB: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | QUICK READ

Iran’s Ghalibaf will not attend BRICS Parliamentary Forum in Delhi: Embassy

India is hosting the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum in New Delhi on October 26 and 27. The event brings together presiding speakers and lawmakers from BRICS member and partner countries. The core theme of the conference is strengthening parliaments for people-centric development. Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla is chairing the gathering held at the Central Hall of Samvidhan Sadan.

Hindustan Times: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY | QUICK READ

NHAI Issues Guidelines for Upgradation, Maintenance and Smart Monitoring of Toilet Facilities & Parking at National Highway Toll Plazas

The National Highways Authority of India issued comprehensive guidelines for the upgradation, maintenance, and smart monitoring of public toilets and parking areas at toll plazas. The initiative aims to improve public amenities by ensuring cleanliness, safety, accessibility, and essential services for national highway users. Existing toilets will undergo technical assessments before rehabilitation covering flooring, plumbing, lighting, ventilation, and sanitary fittings.

PIB: source

ECONOMY | AGREEMENT/MOU | QUICK READ

NLC India Signs MoUs For Rs. 37,000 Crore Odisha Investment, Focusing On Power, Minerals, And Gasification

NLC India Limited signed Memorandums of Understanding with the Industrial Promotion and Investment Corporation of Odisha Limited on 22 October 2026. The agreements involve a total tentative investment of Rs 37,000 crore focusing on power, minerals, and coal gasification projects in Odisha. NLCIL will develop a 3200 MW ultra-super critical coal-based thermal power plant with an investment of Rs 35,000 crore, creating 4,000 jobs.

freepressjournal.in: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY QUICK READ

Shri Shivraj Singh Chouhan Launches Enhanced NMMS App Version with Advanced Security Features for VB-G RAM G

Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan launched an upgraded version of the National Mobile Monitoring System app for the VB-G RAM G scheme. The launch aims to prevent fake attendance, protect rural workers' wages, and ensure transparent use of public funds. The core issue addressed is the occurrence of fake attendance and wage claims made in the names of other individuals.

PIB: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY REPORT/INDEX QUICK READ

Department of Pharmaceuticals Constitutes Committee to Review Pharmaceutical Marketing Practices

The Department of Pharmaceuticals, Ministry of Chemicals and Fertilizers, has constituted a Committee to comprehensively examine the existing regulatory framework governing pharmaceutical marketing practices and recommend measures to strengthen oversight, monitoring and enforcement mechanisms to curb unethical practices in the pharmaceutical sector .

PIB: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

Indias First Maritime NBFC SMFCL Scales up with Rs 5,107 Crs Disbursed, Aims for Rs 60,205 Crs by 2031

The corporate office of SMFCL was newly inaugurated in New Delhi, highlighting its financial progress and future targets.

PIB: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

RBI asks banks, payment firms to forensically clear tech environments in case of a data breach

The RBI issued these directives to mandate immediate forensic clearance and credential protection following data breaches in financial entities. The RBI has directed banks and payment firms to implement strict security measures, including removing administrative interfaces from the public internet and auditing codebases, in the event of a data breach.

Economic Times: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

Satellite lights, Google searches cut state growth estimation errors by up to 62%: RBI study

A study published in the RBI October Bulletin found that combining satellite night-time lights and Google search data improves state economic growth estimates. The framework was developed because Gross State Value Added figures are released annually with a 12 to 18 month lag, hindering real-time assessment. The model combines satellite imagery of night-time illumination with Google Trends search indices across 25 categories like jobs, finance, and real estate.

Economic Times: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

NDTV World Summit | "US Protecting Its Interest": S Jaishankar On Donald Trump's Oil Deal With Russia

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar stated that the US oil deal with Russia shows the US is protecting its own interests. US President Donald Trump announced a diesel deal with Russian President Vladimir Putin on October 9 to supply multiple tranches of diesel. Trump defended the arrangement by stating it serves American interests under an America First policy.

NDTV: source

HISTORY, ART & CULTURE QUICK READ

Vadnagar UNESCO Bid Targets World Heritage Status by 2028

Vadnagar's nomination target of 2028 for UNESCO World Heritage Site status was reported. A heritage bid has been targeted to secure UNESCO World Heritage status for Vadnagar by 2028.

Urban Acres: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY SPECIES QUICK READ

Coral Reefs Face Collapse by 2075, IUCN Warns

The International Union for Conservation of Nature warned that nearly all shallow-water coral reefs face an extremely high risk of collapse by 2075. In the first systematic survey of 127 tropical and subtropical coral reef systems, 96% were classified as critically endangered. Climate change induced heat stress is identified as the single most consistent threat driving global coral reef decline.

dw.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY PLACE IN NEWS QUICK READ

Beyond The Ramsar Tag: The Conservation Story Of Chandigarh’s Sukhna Wetland

The conservation story and ecological significance of Sukhna wetland were highlighted in a recent feature report. The article explores the conservation history, challenges, and ongoing protection efforts surrounding Chandigarh's Sukhna wetland.

Outlook Traveller: source

ECONOMY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

Chandigarh Administration and RBI Sign MoU for Structured Management of Tax Receipts

The signing of the official Memorandum of Understanding between Chandigarh and the RBI put the development in the news. The Chandigarh Administration and the Reserve Bank of India signed an MoU for the structured management of tax receipts.

:: India News Calling ::: source

INTERNAL SECURITY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

CISF upgraded training: CISF, NeGD sign MoU to train personnel in drone technology, AI and cyber security

The Central Industrial Security Force signed an MoU with the National e-Governance Division to train its personnel in advanced technologies. The agreement addresses growing technology-driven threats to critical infrastructure like airports, nuclear plants, and metro systems. NeGD will act as the knowledge partner, identifying academic and technical institutions and expert faculty for training programmes.

zeenews.india.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

India’s IIT Madras and Dialog Axiata sign MoU to boost tech collaboration in Sri Lanka

IITM Pravartak signed a Memorandum of Understanding with Sri Lanka's Dialog Axiata PLC to support the country's research and innovation ecosystem. The partnership is designed to connect universities and startups with technological expertise, business support, and market access. The agreement aims to strengthen deep tech and innovation partnerships between India and Sri Lanka.

newsonair.gov.in: source

HEALTH ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

De-notification of MSMER-2023 doesn't dilute regulatory oversight, Medical Education Standards: NMC

The National Medical Commission stated that de-notifying MSMER-2023 does not dilute prescribed medical education standards or regulatory oversight. The de-notification aims to remove overlapping procedures and duplication caused by a parallel mechanism of institutional evaluation. The Commission took this decision following judicial observations and a detailed examination of the statutory framework of the NMC Act.

msn.com: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS3 UPSC Editorial Analysis: Air Pollution in Delhi-NCR

The editorial argues that high-tech interventions like satellite tracking, smog towers, and artificial rain cannot replace fundamental ground-level governance and policy reforms in tackling Delhi-NCR's winter air pollution. The trigger is the recurring severe air pollution crisis in the National Capital Region every winter, driven by geographical, meteorological, and socio-economic factors. The core issue is the over-reliance on episodic emergency measures and high-tech surveillance while ignoring structural ground-level challenges, regulatory capacity constraints, and airshed fragmentation.

Insights on India

GS2 Tied by Geography, Divided by Politics

Bangladesh is almost surrounded by India with a border exceeding 4,000 km, leading to deep-seated geopolitical anxieties. Post-Mujib governments shifted toward Islamic nationalism and sought strategic autonomy by engaging China, Pakistan, and the US. Domestic politics in Bangladesh are sharply polarized, with the Awami League favoring India and the BNP remaining suspicious. India's close alignment with Sheikh Hasina's authoritarian rule created severe public resentment and a major foreign policy crisis in 2024.

The Hindu

GS3 Rethinking the defence PSU model

The author argues that while corporatisation of the Ordnance Factory Board into seven DPSUs brought reported profits and export orders, commercial metrics should not overshadow strategic priorities. Reported financial improvements may be exaggerated by a low pandemic-disturbed FY 2019-20 baseline and accounting shifts where inter-factory transfers are now recorded as commercial sales. An excessive focus on EBITDA and short-term returns risks sidelining crucial investments in long-term modernisation, research and development, and complex defence technologies.

BusinessLine

GS3 A fool-proof job scheme, anyone?

The opinion piece appeared in Deccan Herald addressing ongoing debates regarding employment generation schemes. An editorial discussing the complexities, structural challenges, and policy debates surrounding job guarantee schemes in India. A fool-proof job scheme, anyone?

Deccan Herald

GS3 Limits of satellite internet plan

Yet its role in India's connectivity strategy must be assessed against limited bandwidth, scarce spectrum and service costs. Although satellite networks can complement existing infrastructure, they cannot independently meet… India is regulating satellite broadband as rural policy. The physics makes it a premium product. Clearances cannot change arithmetic

BusinessLine

GS2 For migrant children, access to school is not enough

Seasonal migration across India is seeing a new dimension with drought turning seasonal migrants into climate migrants. Intense drought and shrinking livelihoods are pushing families towards worksites like sugarcane fields, brick kilns, and construction sites. Children accompanying migrating parents face interrupted schooling, severe learning loss, and the risk of prolonged educational exclusion. A recent NITI Aayog report highlights that educational disruptions lasting five to six months widen learning gaps and cause dropouts.

ForumIAS

GS2 Census: Democratic Tool, Not Political Abacus

It is in the news due to debates surrounding the postponement and management of the decennial census exercise. The editorial argues that the census must be treated as an essential democratic tool for welfare and planning rather than a political counter.

EPW

GS2 Ram Madhav: As US verdict on Trump nears, India draws line on coercion

The upcoming US political verdict involving Donald Trump has brought focus to the future trajectory of India-US relations. An editorial examining India's firm diplomatic posture against external coercion and its strategic approach toward shifting political dynamics in the United States.

Indian Express

GS2 ECI's course correction is welcome, need for accountability remains

The Election Commission of India has undertaken corrective measures and rolled back several controversial decisions following widespread outrage and an investigation. The trigger was a September 23 media investigation exposing that Election Commissioners had repeatedly objected on record to poll panel steps. The core issue is whether these hasty rollbacks constitute genuine remorse or an attempt to cover tracks after alleged mass disenfranchisement. Changes to Form 6 were dropped for non-SIR states, and BLOs were instructed to visit homes of those notified for logical discrepancies.

msn.com

GS2 GS3 Unified Pension Scheme

The ongoing policy discussions and stakeholder responses regarding the implementation of the Unified Pension Scheme. An editorial evaluation of the Unified Pension Scheme, examining its structure, fiscal implications, and the ongoing debate surrounding government employee pensions.

EPW

GS3 Why the minutes of RBI's rate-setting committee meeting hint at a course correction

The publication of the minutes from the latest rate-setting committee meeting brought this analytical misstep and the subsequent need for course correction to light. The minutes of the Reserve Bank of India rate-setting committee reveal a sharp shift in outlook, indicating that the inflationary impact of foreign currency non-resident bank deposits was previously underestimated. The stark change in the stance of members from the prior policy meeting in August suggests that the inflationary impact of the foreign currency non-resident (bank) deposits was underestimated.

Mint

GS3 Inflation warrants early distress control

Inflation has steadily increased since January, with consumer prices rising by 0.69% between August and September. The surge in inflationary pressures stems from crude price hikes due to the West Asia war, a depreciating rupee, and a deficient monsoon causing drought-like conditions. Rising oil prices inflate transport costs, while a weak rupee imports inflation, and impending El Nino weather disruptions threaten winter crops. The RBI predicts higher inflation for remaining months, and the IMF warns of renewed pressure on India if energy prices remain high.

Deccan Herald

GS3 Beyond resilience: lessons for India from the IMF-World Bank meetings

The annual IMF-World Bank meetings put global economic trends and India's growth strategy in the spotlight. The editorial discusses lessons for India from the IMF-World Bank meetings, emphasizing the need for quality jobs, responsible AI integration, and global resilience. India's next phase of growth must go beyond strong GDP numbers to create quality jobs, harness AI responsibly and build resilience against global shocks.

Mint

GS2 GS3 Failing to protect privacy online

A New Mexico judge ordered Meta to pay a $25 billion penalty for deceiving Facebook users regarding data privacy control. The ruling revives concerns from the Cambridge Analytica scandal, which harvested profile data of about 87 million users for voter targeting. Indian institutions also show a cavalier approach to data safety, exemplified by recent security lapses at SBI, eMudhra, and AIIMS. State Bank of India disclosed that customer records were found on the dark web, taking five days to file after the alert.

Hindustan Times

GS2 Should children be involved in political campaigning?

The issue came to the forefront following observations made by Justice D. Bharatha Chakravarthy of the Madras High Court. The Madras High Court suggested that Parliament should consider making the involvement of children in political campaigning a valid ground for setting aside an election. Justice D. Bharatha Chakravarthy of the Madras High Court recently said that it was for Parliament to consider whether involving children in campaigning should be made a ground for setting aside the election of candidates

The Hindu

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Explained: What do the National Medical Commission's new guidelines say about advertising in medicine? The new guidelines were put in the news through a detailed explainer discussing their stance on medical advertising and commercialisation. The National Medical Commission issued new guidelines restricting medical advertising, barring misleading claims of guaranteed cures while permitting factual disclosures of services and credentials.

The Hindu

Shamonda virus, the livestock pathogen detected in human for the first time The recent unprecedented detection of the livestock virus in a human host has put public health authorities on alert. The Shamonda virus, typically a pathogen affecting livestock, has been detected in a human for the first time, triggering public health investigations.

The Hindu

Climate Reparation: Loss and Damage A newly established international climate fund allocated US$20 million to Nepal for flash flood recovery, making it the first country to receive Loss and Damage funding. Developing countries demand climate reparations because they suffer the most from extreme weather events while having negligible historical contributions to greenhouse gas emissions.

ForumIAS

What is the importance of the UN Loss and Damage Fund's payout to Nepal? The payout to Nepal brought focus to the status and implementation of the UN Loss and Damage Fund. Nepal received financial assistance from the UN Loss and Damage Fund, highlighting the operationalisation of global climate compensation mechanisms.

The Hindu

Parents To Pay For Damage Caused By Student Protesters? The Crackdown In France, Italy Explained The issue is in the news due to recent intense student demonstrations and subsequent legislative proposals in France and Italy. France and Italy are cracking down on student protests by exploring laws that hold parents financially or legally liable for property damage caused by minor protesters.

News18

Experts Explain | How India can make its Rs 20,000 crore carbon capture investment count The discussion is in the news due to growing policy focus and substantial financial commitments toward industrial decarbonisation in India. This explainer details the strategies, challenges, and economic considerations for deploying India's Rs 20,000 crore investment in carbon capture and storage technologies.

Indian Express

Knowledge Nugget | What makes Mangroves a unique and vital ecosystem? The ecosystem is highlighted as part of an educational knowledge nugget series for UPSC civil services aspirants. Mangroves are unique salt-tolerant intertidal forest ecosystems that provide essential ecological and coastal protection services.

Indian Express

Poland's abortion law: What will the new bills change? The introduction of new bills amid protests and political uncertainty ahead of elections put the law in the news. Poland's restrictive abortion law faces two new legislative bills aimed at easing current limits. Poland's restrictive abortion law faces two new bills aiming to ease limits, amid protests and political uncertainty ahead of elections.

The Hindu

Explained: Modi-Tusk Talks Seek To Deepen India-Poland Strategic Partnership With Defence, Tech And Trade In Focus The bilateral talks between the Indian and Polish Prime Ministers put the strategic partnership in focus. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk held high-level talks to strengthen bilateral relations by focusing on defence, technology, and trade cooperation.

ETV Bharat

Pete Hegseth approves heat ray testing: How dangerous is the US military weapon? Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth approved a seven-month loan of the Active Denial System to the Department of Homeland Security for border testing. The heat ray weapon uses invisible electromagnetic energy beams to produce an intense burning sensation on human skin.
msn.com

Trump, Putin And Xi To Decide Ukraine's Fate Without Zelenskyy? What Moscow Wants And What's China's Role? Russian President Vladimir Putin proposed a trilateral meeting with US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the APEC summit. The proposed meeting excludes Ukraine and the European Union, raising concerns about major powers deciding a sovereign nation's fate without its participation.
news18.com

Why a labour rights activist's detention has put a broad China law under scrutiny The recent detention of the labour rights activist placed China's restrictive legal provisions under international spotlight. The detention of a labour rights activist in China has brought intense scrutiny upon the country's broad and vaguely worded legal statutes.
Indian Express

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- Exercise SIMBEX 2026 (Defence) Vajiram & Ravi
- Oil India discovers natural gas in shallow Krishna-Godavari waters (Economy) Business Standard
- Data suggests broad-based increase in food prices: RBI Bulletin (Economy) The Hindu
- Soliciting public opinion and stake holders input on Design of Network Architecture for the proposed Broadband Public Protection and Disaster Relief (BB-PPDR) System (Internal Security) PIB
- India private sector growth hits four-month high in Oct: HSBC flash PMI (Economy) Business Standard
- India moves to development phase of national action plan for inland small-scale fisheries (Agriculture & Allied) PIB
- Arabian Black Electric Ray (Environment & Ecology) Vajiram & Ravi
- "Problem Caused By You": Piyush Goyal Challenges Europe's Climate Stance (International Relations) NDTV
- Yes Bank unlikely to pay AT-1 Bond coupons this year despite Supreme Court ruling: Report (Economy) Business Today
- Department of Commerce and EEPC India Hold Chintan Shivir to Chart Strategy for US $250 Billion Engineering Exports by 2030 (Economy) PIB
- "In times of international conflict, moral courage is often tested by the willingness to uphold humanitarian principles despite strategic pressures." Comment. (Ethics & Integrity) Insights on India
- IPCC fails to agree on climate science report timeline for sixth time, drawing criticism from vulnerable nations (Environment & Ecology) Down To Earth
- LGs, administrators of all Union Territories delegated powers to discharge function under National Dental Commission Act, 2023 (Polity & Constitution) ANI News
- Delhi High Court Upholds Cash Assistance In Lieu Of School Uniforms For EWS Students, Rejects Review Plea (Social Justice & Welfare) LiveLaw
- Researchers Identify Two New Ophiorrhiza Species in Arunachal Pradesh (Environment & Ecology) India Today NE
- India's forex reserves decline USD 5 bn to USD 721 bn (Economy) ThePrint
- Home Ministry to launch pilot initiative to establish vibrant Civil Defence Network (Internal Security) All India Radio (NewsOnAir)
- WHO adopts India-initiated resolution on digital health (Health) eHealth Magazine
- Impact of Supreme Court rulings on past High Court decisions: ITC denial under Section 16(2)(c) of CGST Act (Economy) TaxCorp AI
- Karnataka High Court issues additional guidelines to prevent arbitrary use of power by police for registering FIRs based on social media posts (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- India resilient to global shocks, but inflation risks rise: RBI Bulletin (Economy) The Financial Express
- Trafficking Or Voluntary Sex Work? Supreme Court Asks National Judicial Academy To Frame Guidelines For... (Polity & Constitution) LawBeat
- Tadoba Tiger Reserve in Maharashtra Turns To Smart Sensors To Ensure Adequate Water For Animals (Environment & Ecology) NDTV Profit
- Cyclone Arnab alert: IMD forecasts landfall in Andhra Pradesh on Oct 28 (Disaster Management) Newstrack English
- India says peace along China border essential for growth in bilateral ties (International Relations) BusinessLine
- We have to develop our own AI layer for military services: Defence Secretary (Science & Technology) Economic Times
- Govt to issue consultation paper on a new AI law in 'coming weeks': Ashwini Vaishnaw (Science & Technology) Hindustan Times
- 21,900 digital arrest complaints registered till Sept: MHA to SC (Internal Security) Hindustan Times
- Fiscal Federalism On Trial: Article 131 And Constitutional Economics Of State Borrowing (Polity & Constitution) Live Law
- Profitability No Ground To Stall Insolvency Process Under IBC: Supreme Court (Economy) Deccan Herald
- Supreme Court Orders States To Ground-Truth, Demarcate All Water Bodies (Environment & Ecology) LawBeat
- UN Losing Legitimacy Over Unrepresentative Security Council: India (International Relations) Revoi.in

- Why Did NITI Aayog Question BA, B.Sc & B.Com Degrees? (Education) jeevanutsahnews.in
- MPC minutes: Two more interest rate hikes on cards, maybe even a third (Economy) Economic Times
- How will platforms detect child abuse material? Supreme Court proposes a National Hash & URL Database, Time-Bound Reporting; Recognises right to internet access (Governance & Policy) SCC Online
- Supreme Court: Gift of temple inam property to State Government void ab initio; State is custodian, not owner (Polity & Constitution) SCC Online
- Govt eyes stake cuts in 4 PSU banks, including Central Bank, UCO Bank; 2 more in privatisation plan (Economy) Moneycontrol.com
- India's Factory Employment Grew 7.2% in 2024-25, Outpacing Growth in Nominal Value Added per Worker (Economy) FACTLY
- Maldives entering Pak orbit? Muizzu signs defence deals, calls for Saarc revival (International Relations) India Today
- Unveiling the impact of black hole spin on flickering of light emitted from matter around the black hole (Science & Technology) PIB
- Proposed Amendments to Driving Licence Rules (Governance & Policy) Times of India
- New car safety rules: Rear-crash tests from 2029 to prevent fire, immobilisers from 2027 (Governance & Policy) Times of India
- India's tougher crash tests for carmakers and the Bharat NCAP star rating that goes beyond them (Governance & Policy) Hindustan Times

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 21 must-know, 24 Prelims facts, 43 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — Economy (13), Governance & Policy (7), International Relations (7), Environment & Ecology (5), Agriculture & Allied (2), Defence (2), Science & Technology (2), Social Justice & Welfare (2), Polity & Constitution (1), Infrastructure & Energy (1), History, Art & Culture (1), Internal Security (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in —** Education, Disaster Management, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 5 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: nothing today · Political change in the neighbourhood: nothing today · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 1

Full text — 37 of 72 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — PIB 12, The Hindu 9, Economic Times 5, msn.com 4, Hindustan Times 4, Indian Express 4, Business Standard 3, BusinessLine 3, newsonair.gov.in 2, RBI 2, Vajiram & Ravi 2, Deccan Herald 2, ForumIAS 2, EPW 2

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